

Mac User

AI Accelerator Worksheet

Setting Up Your First MCP Server

Demo Video for reference:  Day 5 Workbook.mp4

Overview

In this activity, you'll be setting up your first MCP (Model Context Protocol) server using Claude Desktop. This is a foundational step toward enabling Claude to interact directly with files on your device—allowing it to read, analyze, summarize, and work with your local documents seamlessly.

Learning Objective

By completing this exercise, you will:

- Understand what an MCP server is and why it matters
- Successfully install and configure a File System MCP Server
- Enable Claude to access and process files securely from a local folder
- Troubleshoot and validate your MCP integration

What is an MCP Server?

An MCP (Model Context Protocol) server is a program that lets AI models like Claude securely access and interact with external data sources, tools, and files. It acts as a bridge, providing live context and capabilities (like reading files, querying databases, or calling APIs) that the AI cannot access on its own. This allows the AI to use up-to-date real-world information and perform tasks beyond just processing what you type. Essentially, it creates a secure, dynamic workspace for the AI to work with external systems and data in real time.

Prerequisites

Before starting, ensure you have the following installed:

1. **Claude Desktop:** Download the latest version from the official Anthropic [website](#).
2. **Node.js:** Download and install the most recent stable version compatible with your system (Windows, macOS, or Linux).
Link to Download - <https://nodejs.org/en/download>

Tip: After installation, verify Node.js by running `node -v` in your terminal.

For Mac :

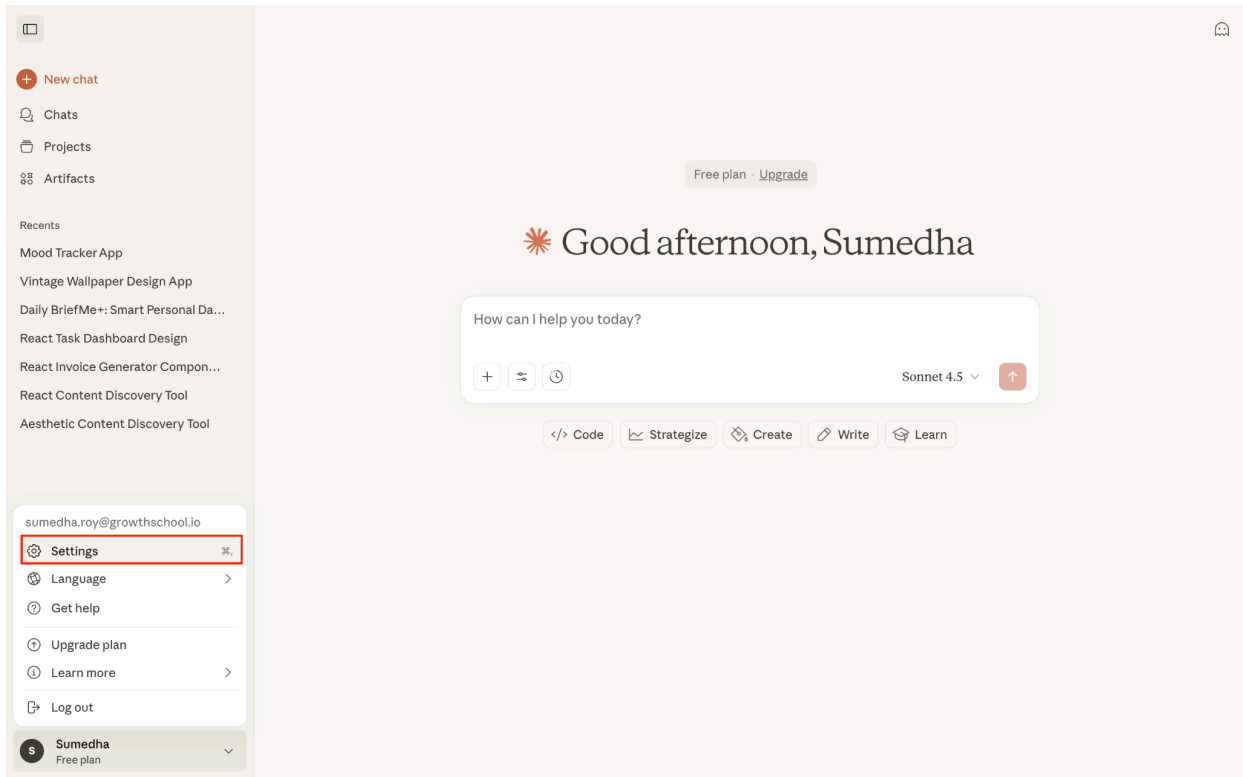
A screenshot of a macOS terminal window titled "sumedha — -zsh — 80x24". The terminal shows the output of the command "node -v". The text in the terminal is: "Last login: Tue Nov 4 13:17:08 on ttys000", "sumedha@Sumedhas-MacBook-Air ~ % node -v", "v24.10.0", and "sumedha@Sumedhas-MacBook-Air ~ %".

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Step-by-Step Instructions

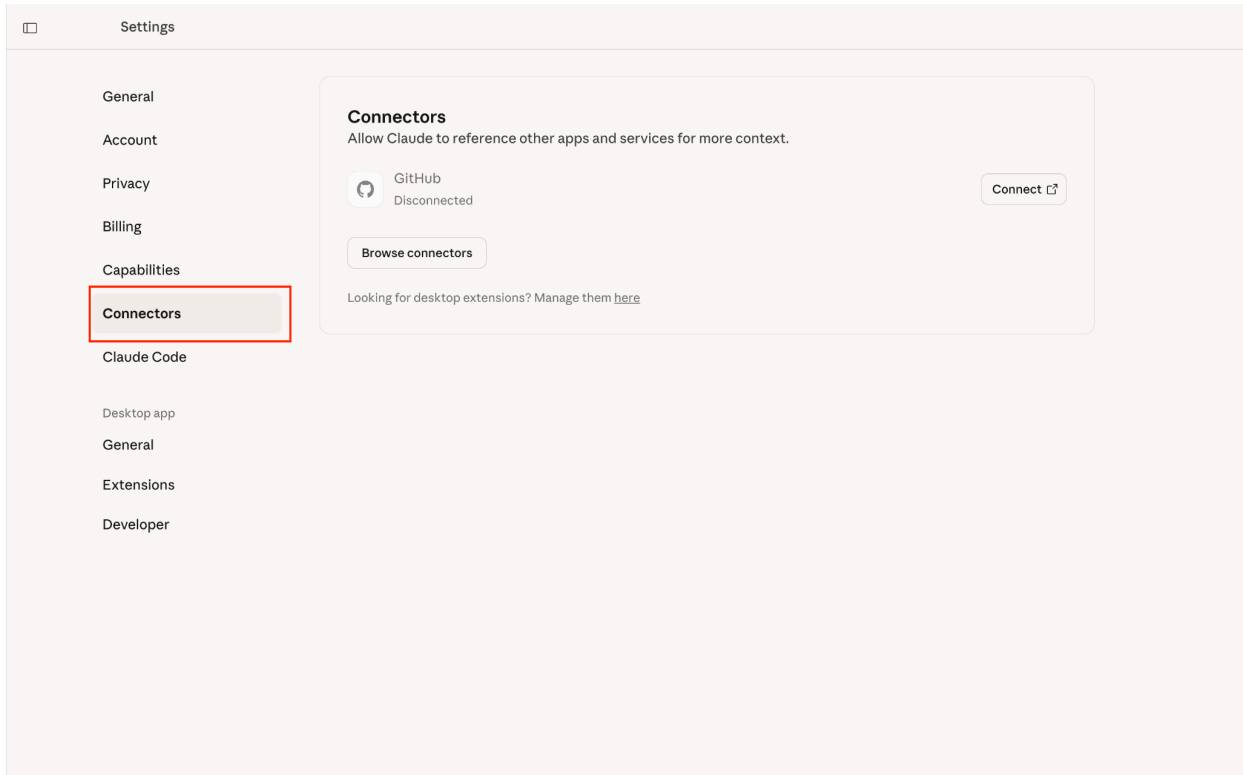
Step 1: Open Claude Desktop

- Launch Claude Desktop from your Applications or Start Menu.
- Open the settings or menu icon in the corner.



Step 2: Access Connectors

- Click **Manage Connectors** to enter the connectors management panel.
- This interface shows all existing connections Claude can use to interact with external systems.

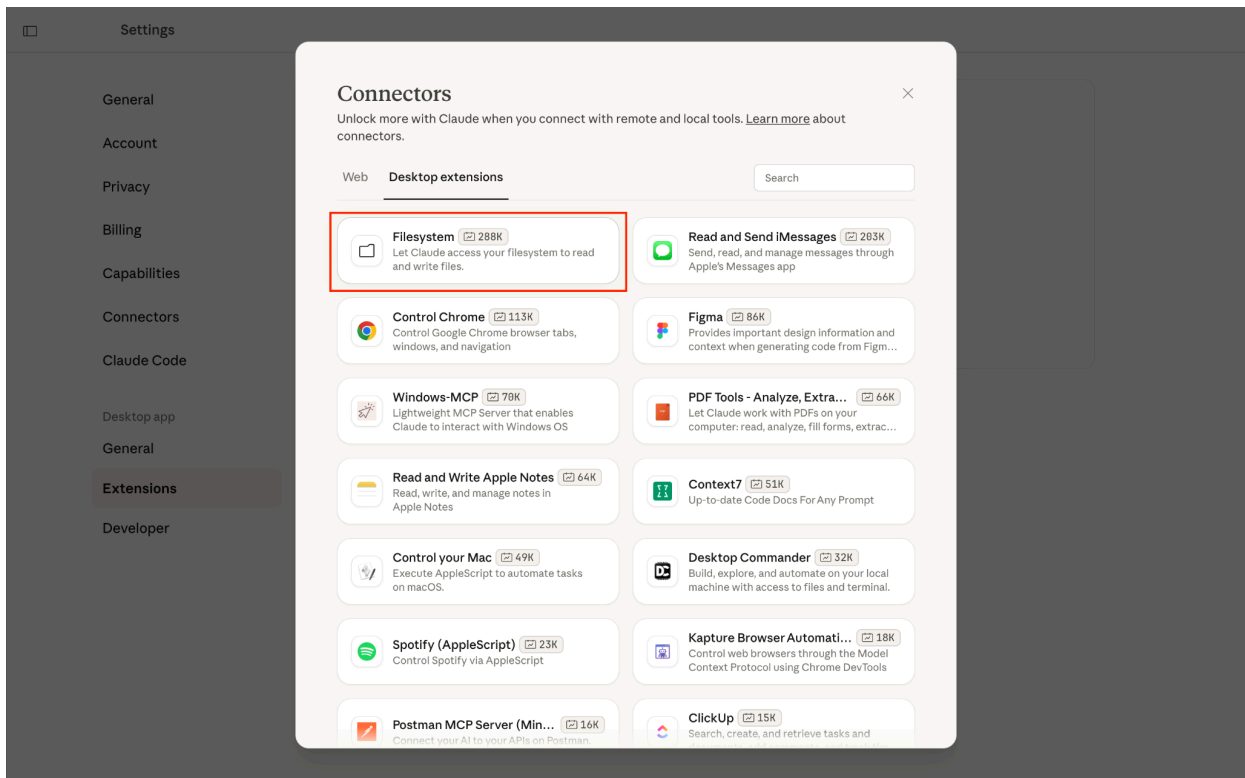
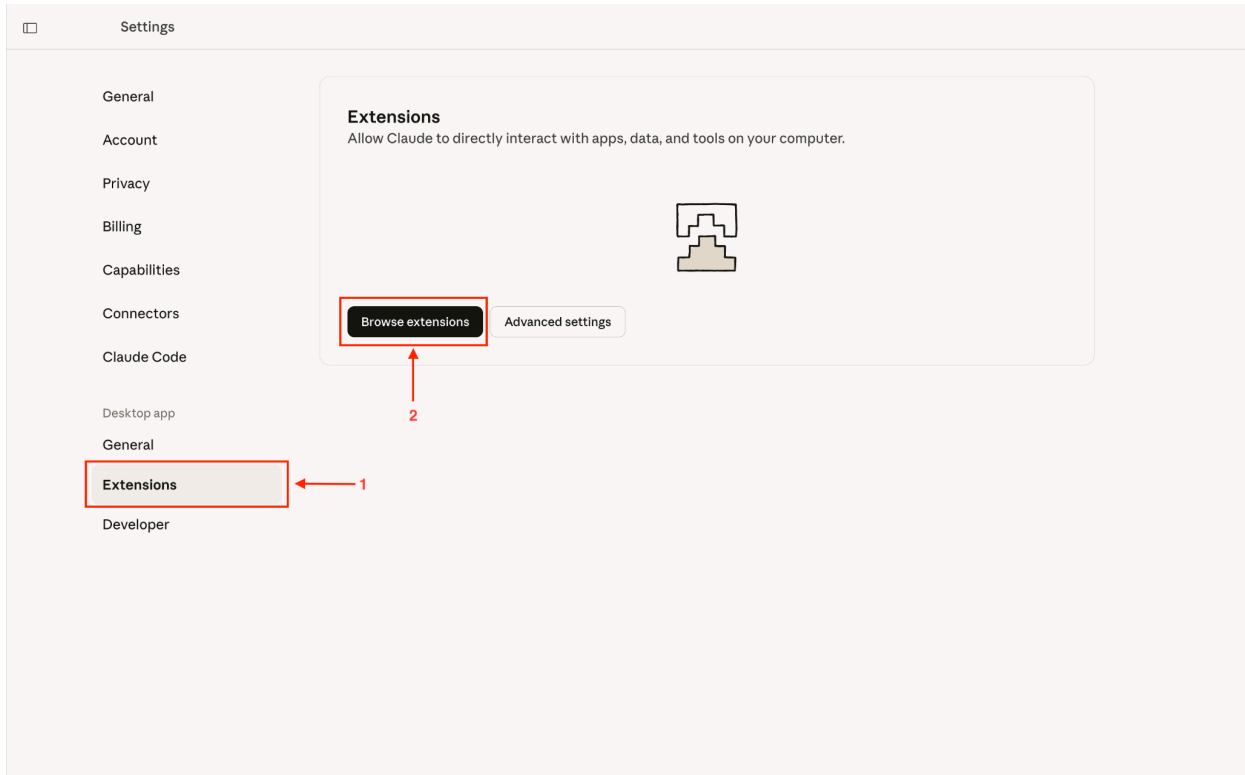


Step 3: Install the File System MCP Server

- Click **Extensions** in the left sidebar.
- Scroll through the list or search for **File System MCP Server**.
- Select it and review the listed requirements.

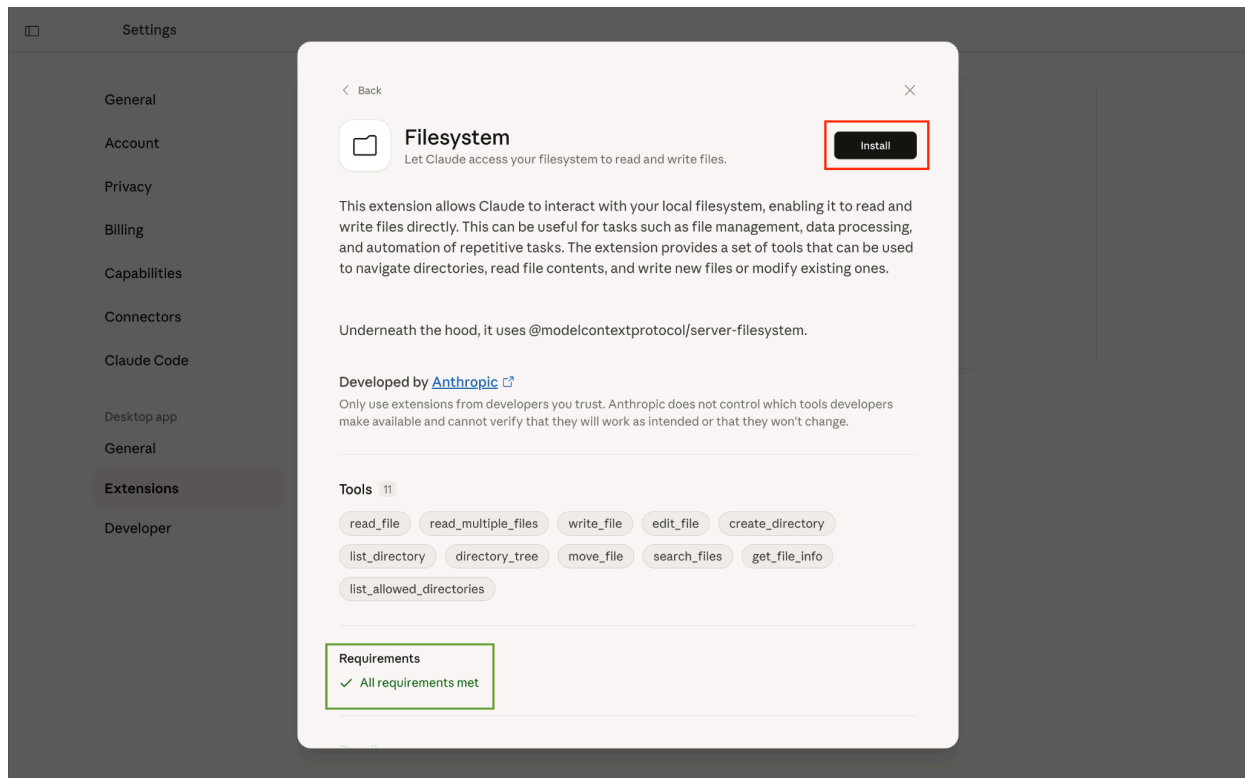
If you see “All requirements are met” , you’re ready to continue.

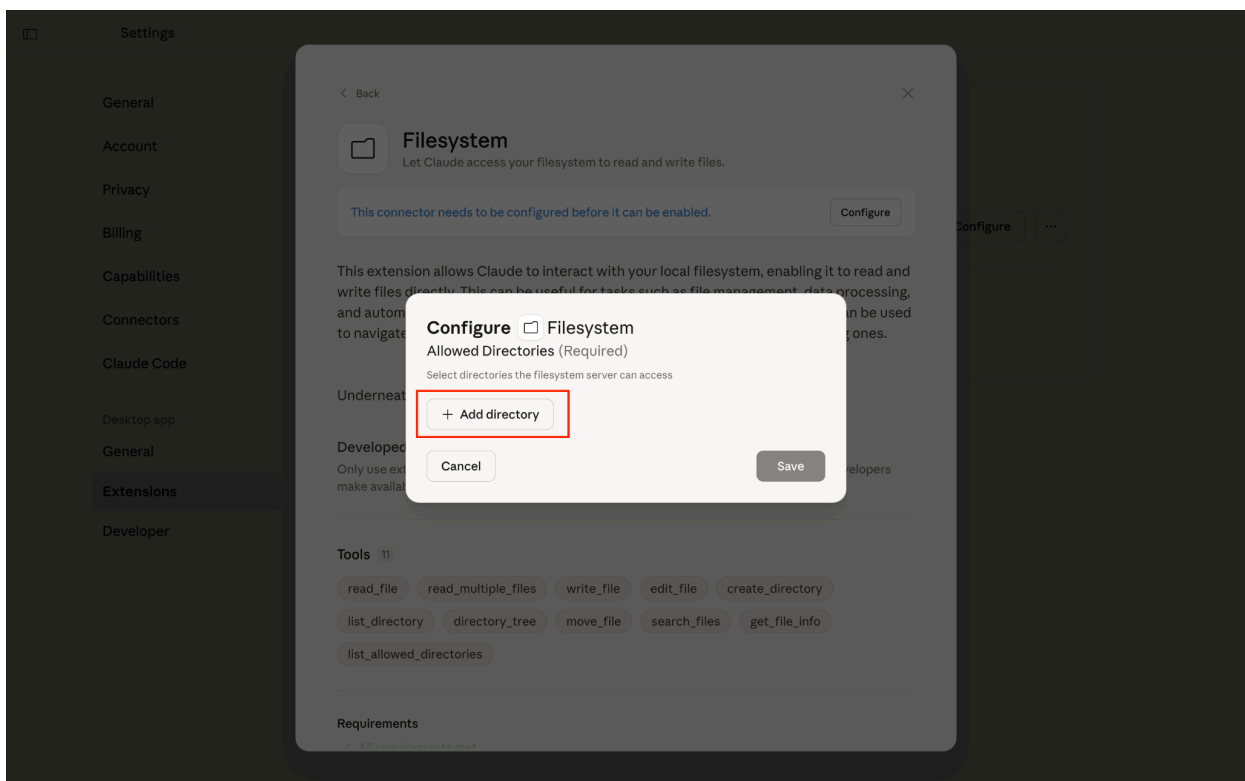
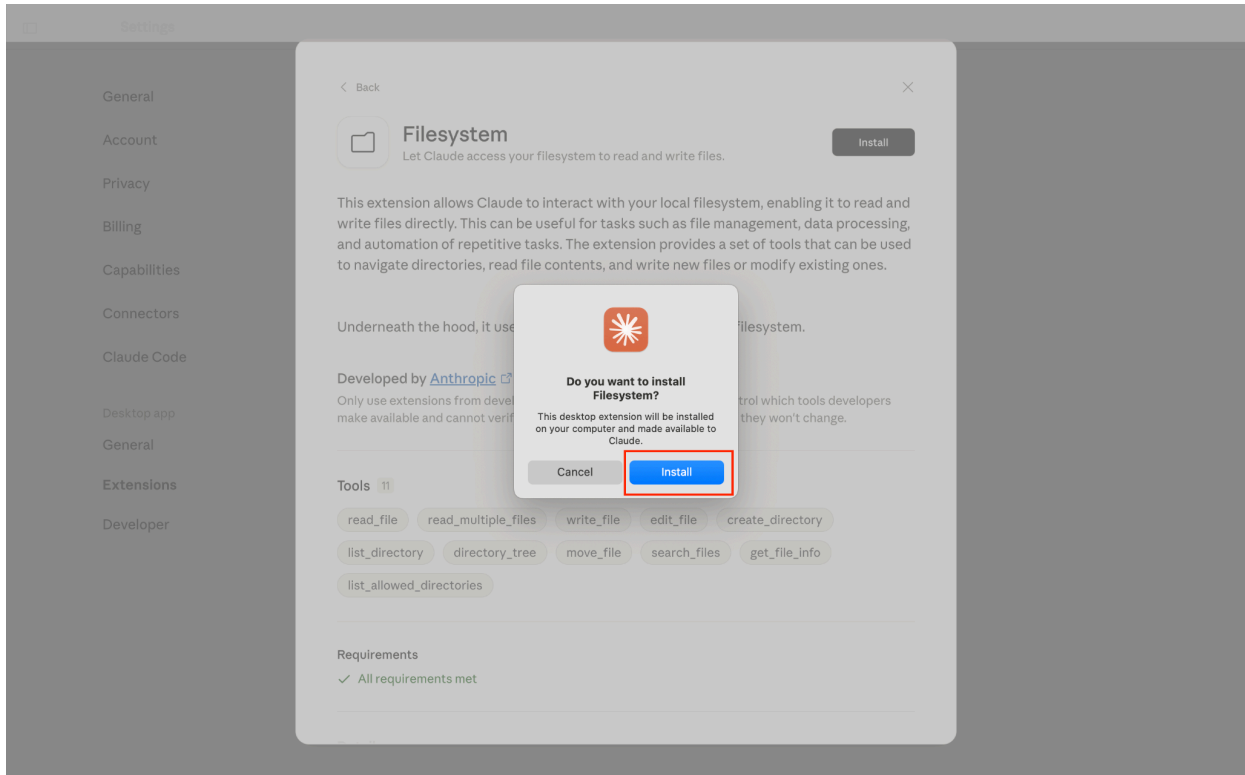
If not, follow the on-screen guidance to resolve any missing dependencies (like Node.js or permission requests).



Step 4: Install and Configure

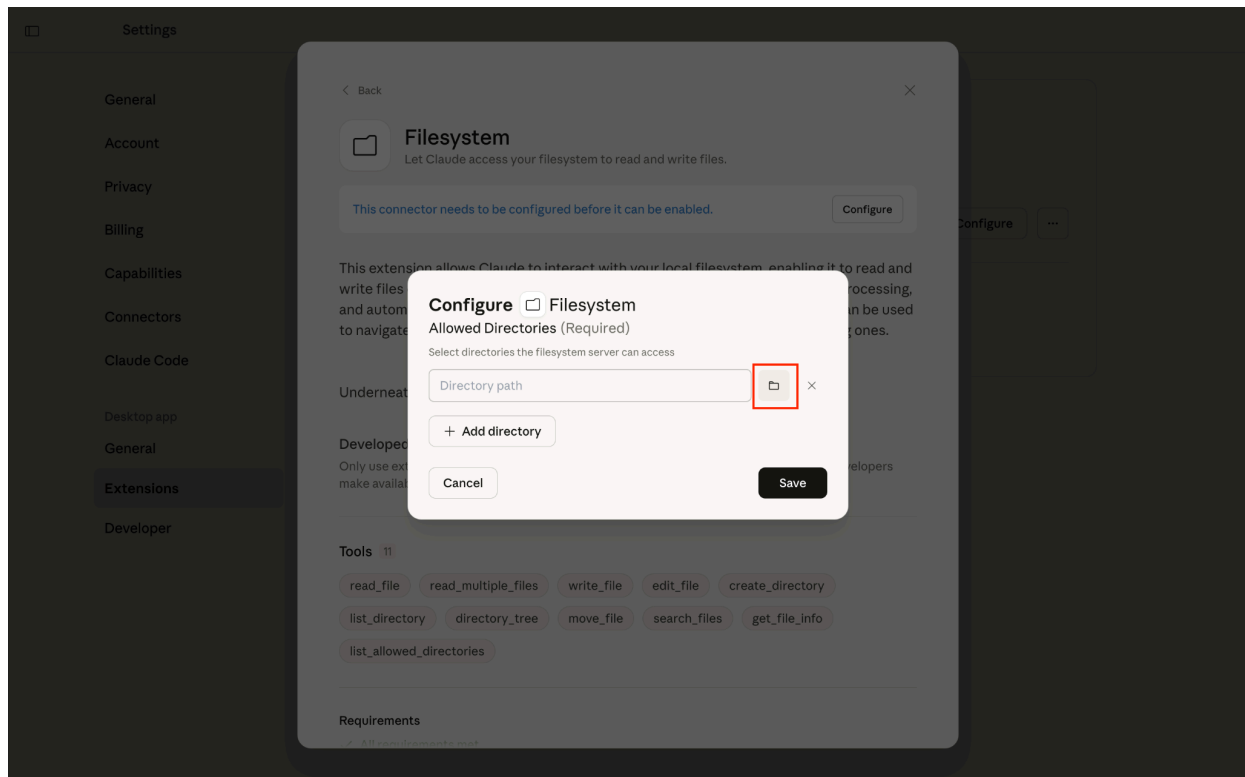
- Click **Install** and grant permission when prompted.
- You'll be asked to select which folders Claude can access. This is crucial for security and privacy.

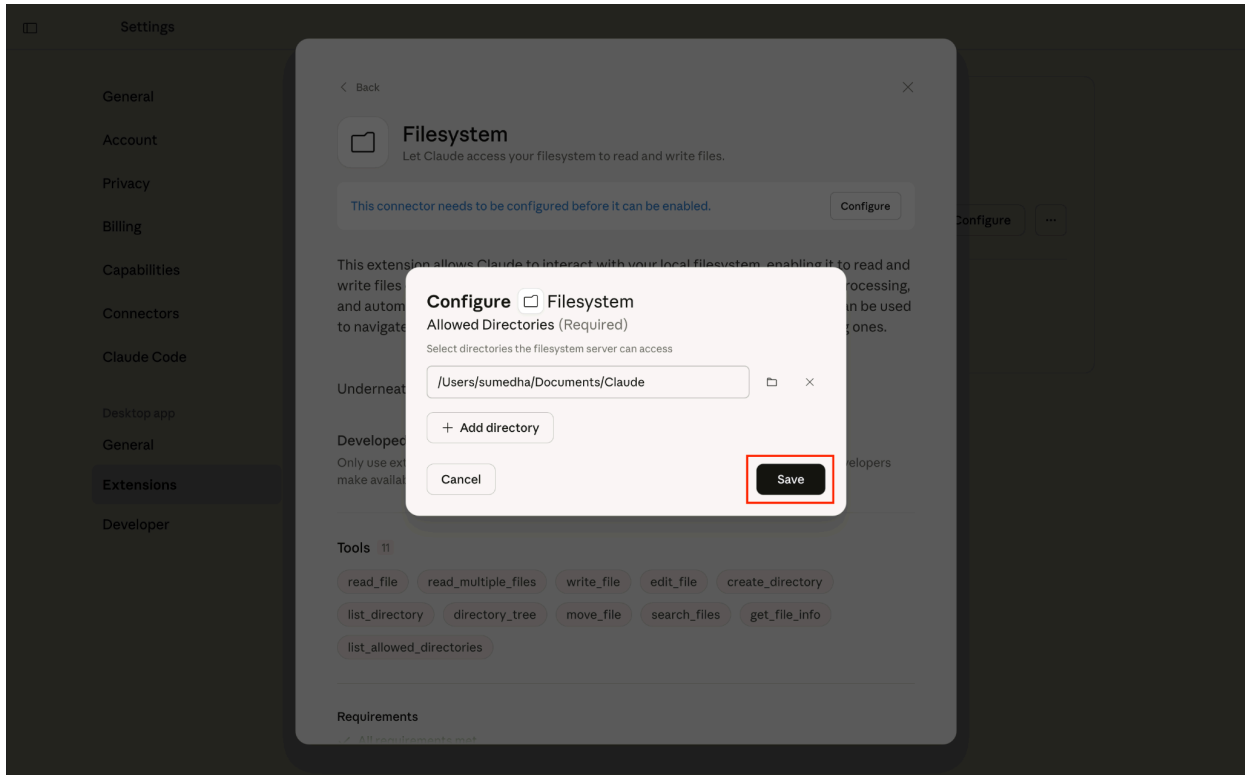




Add Directory Permissions:

1. Click **Add New Folder Access**.
2. Choose a directory you want Claude to read (for example, a “Projects” or “Docs” folder).
3. Confirm by clicking **Save**.

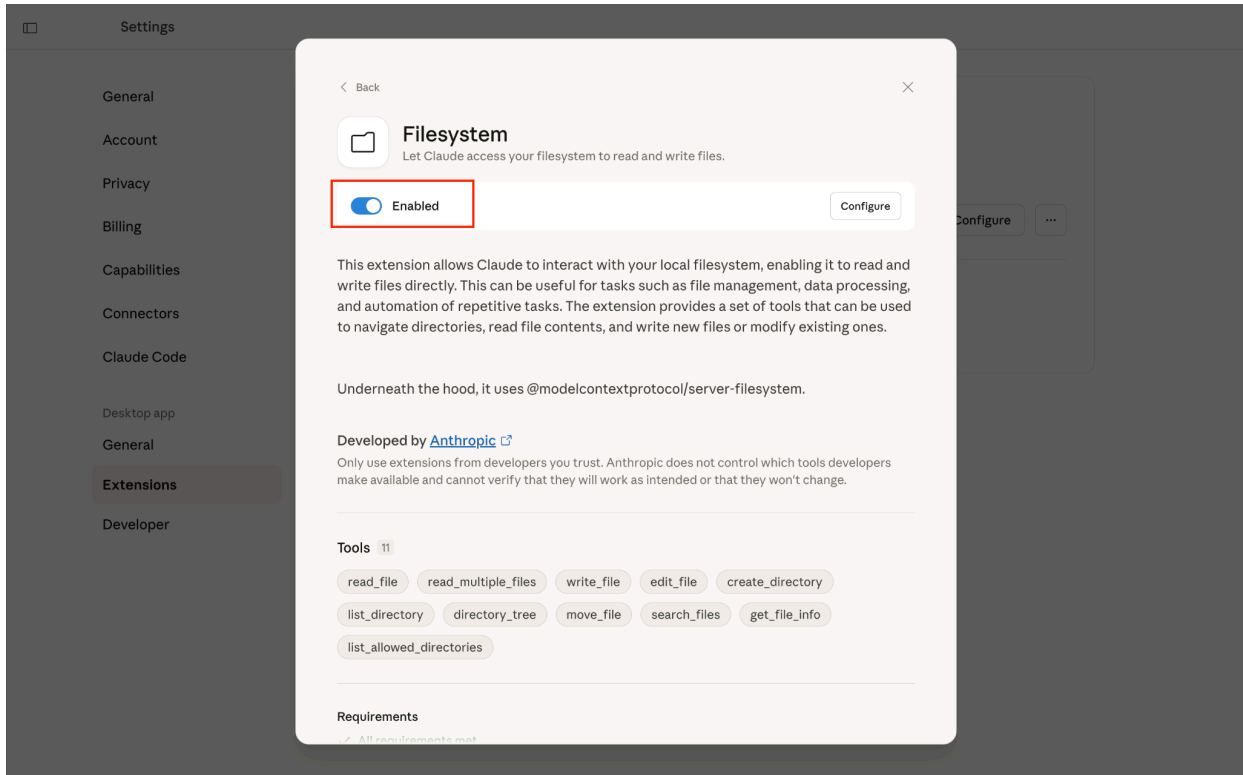




This step defines the boundaries of what Claude can see and interact with — it cannot access files outside of the folders you choose.

Step 5: Enable and Restart

- Ensure your File System MCP Server appears as **Enabled** (toggle it on if necessary).
- Close the settings window and restart Claude for the changes to apply.

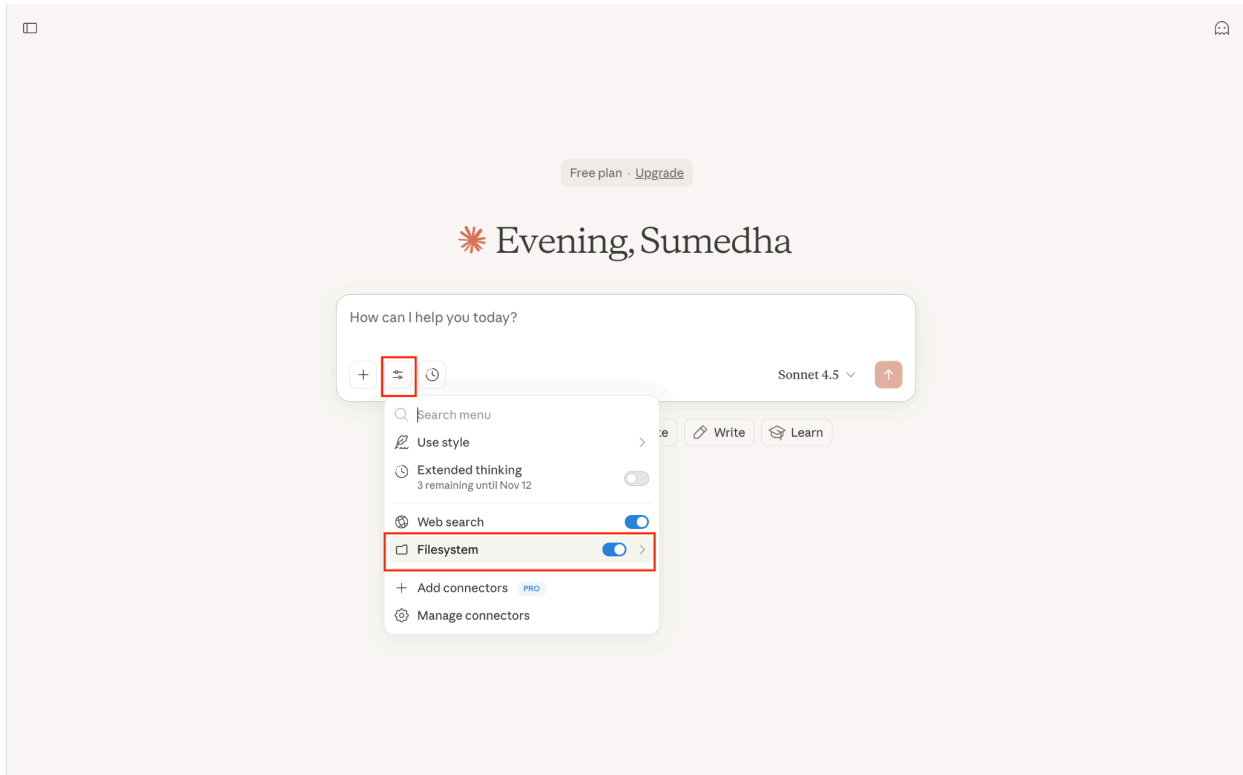


Restart Process:

1. Go to the Claude menu → **Quit Claude**.
2. Reopen the Claude Desktop application.

Quick Check:

In *search and tools*, **Filesystem** should be enabled.



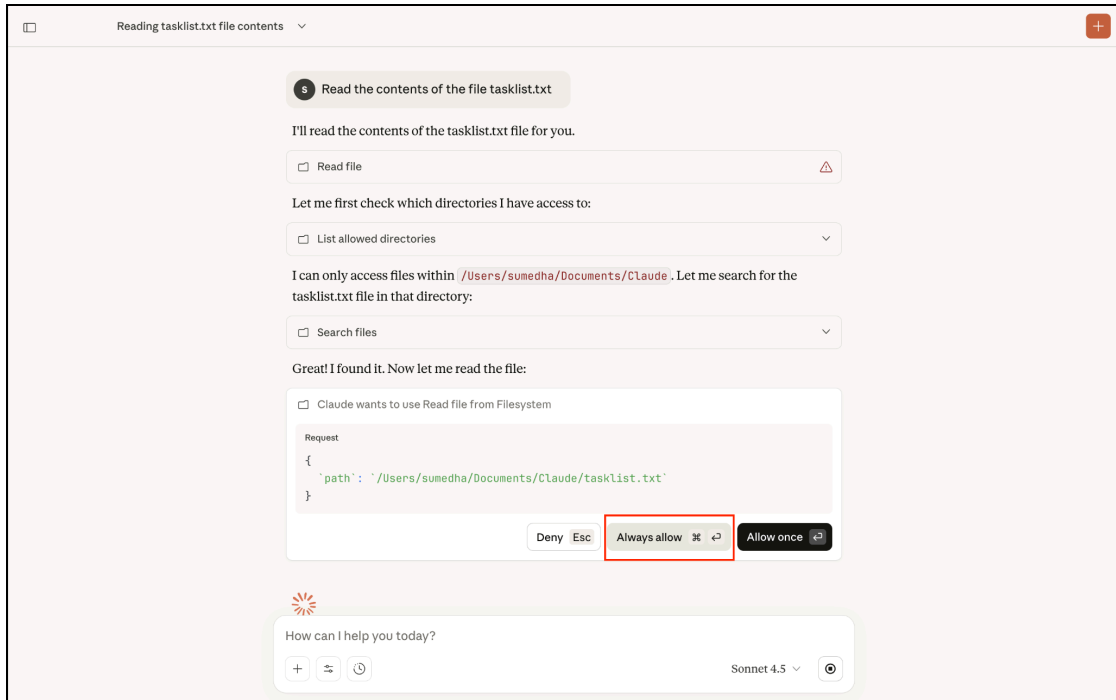
Step 6: Test Your Setup

Once restarted, your MCP server should now be active.

Download the sample files [here](#), and save in the directory you allowed Claude to read.

Try the following test commands inside Claude:

- “Read the contents of the file tasklist.txt”



*[Remember to click “**Always allow**” when asked for permission to access the folder.]*

Claude should now respond using real data from your local files. This confirms that your connection is properly configured.

Troubleshooting Tips

If your MCP server doesn't appear active or doesn't respond:

- Ensure you're running the latest version of **Claude Desktop** and **Node.js**.
- Double-check folder permissions — did you give access to the correct directory?
- Restart Claude after any configuration change.
- Confirm in Connectors that **File System MCP Server** is toggled on and says “Enabled.”
- If you continue experiencing problems, reinstall the extension and repeat the setup steps.

Support and Collaboration

If you encounter any issues:

- Revisit this worksheet and the Troubleshooting section.
- Check the official Anthropic and Node.js documentation.
- Ask questions in your cohort channel or during group sessions.

Remember: Building technical confidence comes from experimentation and curiosity. Don't rush this process and explore how your MCP server enhances workflow integration. Every step you take now strengthens your broader AI skill set.

Using Your MCP Server with Claude Desktop

Prerequisite

- You have successfully set up and enabled the File System MCP server on Claude Desktop.
- You've granted access to at least one folder on your computer.

Resource:

Please ensure you download all the files from the provided link and save them to the directory accessible by Claude.

Download Here -  Sample Data

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1yIkCaYzMITSpvm8UTw65egZ7XNwfpbiQ?usp=drive_link

1. Read a File

Steps:

1. Open Claude Desktop.

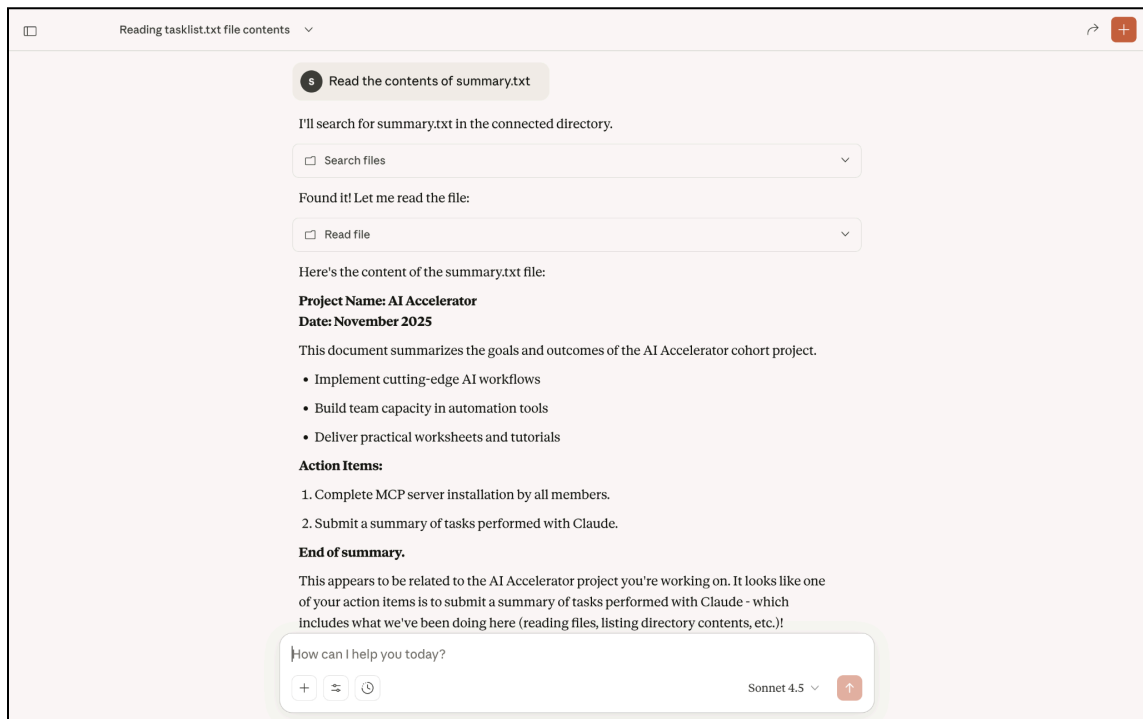
2. In the chat prompt, type:

Read the contents of [file name].
For example: "Read the contents of summary.txt"

3. Press Enter.
4. Wait for Claude's response, it should display the content of the file.

Tips:

- Double-check you typed the correct file name.
- If there's an error, ensure the file is in the accessible folder you selected during setup.



2. Summarize a Document

Steps:

1. Open Claude Desktop.
2. In the chat, type:

Summarize the main ideas in [document name].
For example: "Summarize the main ideas in report.docx"

3. Press Enter.
4. Claude will respond with a concise summary of the document's content.

Tips:

- Works best with text documents (Word, TXT, PDF).
- For non-text files, try converting them or asking for a list of extractable data.

3. List All Files in a Folder

Steps:

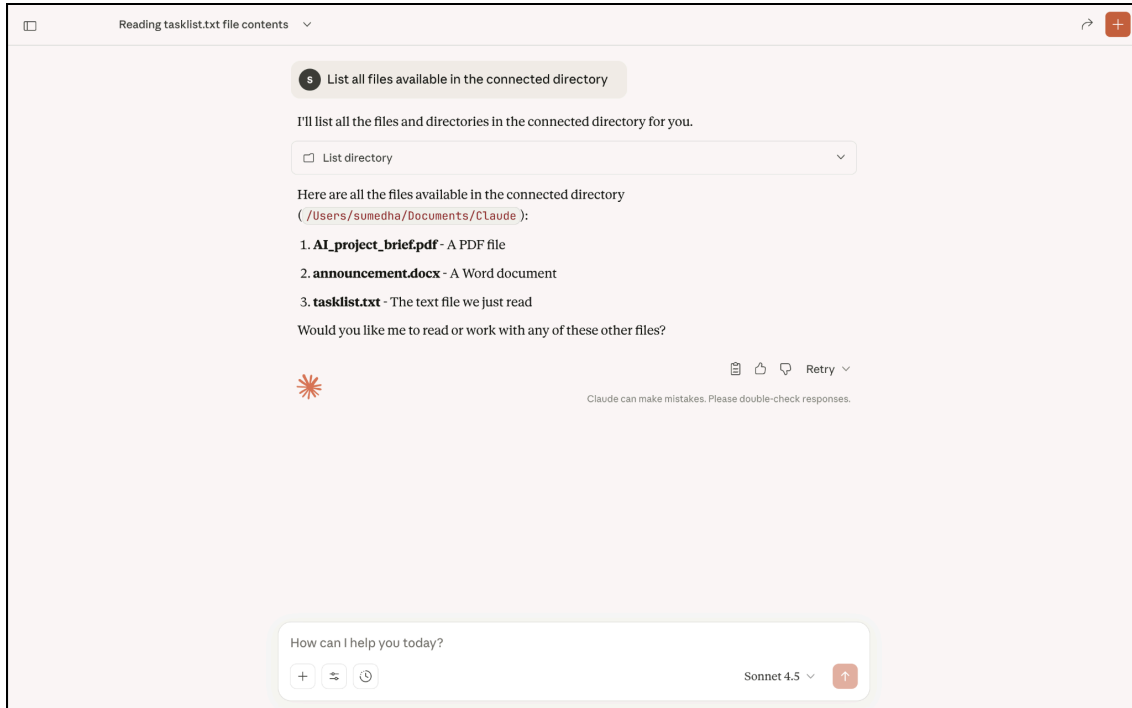
1. Open Claude Desktop.
2. Type:

List all files in my MCP-connected folder.

3. Press Enter.
4. Claude will show a list of file names from your accessible directory.

Tips:

- If you have multiple folders connected, specify which one: "List all files in the 'Projects' folder."



4. Extract Data from a Spreadsheet

Steps:

1. Place your spreadsheet (e.g., budget.xlsx) in your MCP folder.
2. In Claude Desktop, type:

Read the data from budget.csv and list all expense categories.

3. Hit Enter.
4. Claude will extract and display relevant data from the file.

Tips:

- Claude handles .xlsx, .csv, and .tsv formats well.
- If you get errors, make sure the file format is supported and the file is accessible.

5. Compare Two Files

Steps:

1. Place both files in your accessible folder.

2. Type:

Compare draft1.txt and final.txt and highlight the key differences.

3. Press Enter.
4. Claude generates a comparison, listing changes or additions.

Tips:

- Use clear and unique file names.
- Ask for comparisons on content, structure, or keywords as needed.

6. Search for a Keyword in Files

Steps:

1. Type:

Find all files in my folder that mention "strategy".

2. Enter.
3. Claude will list files containing the keyword and may display excerpts.

7. Summarize All Documents in a Folder

Steps:

1. Type:

Summarize the main points from every document in this folder, under each file name.

2. Enter.
3. Claude produces a list with summaries for each document.

Troubleshooting Common Issues

- If Claude says it can't access a file, re-check your directory permissions in "Manage Connectors".
 - Make sure files are in the folder you gave Claude access to; move them if necessary.
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Tips for Taking it Further

- Use Claude to create new files:
"Create a new file called meeting_notes.txt summarizing today's brainstorming session."
- Experiment with combining tasks:
"Read each document and create a summary table with document names and their main takeaway."

Resource:

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Windows User

AI Accelerator Worksheet

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By completing this exercise, you will:

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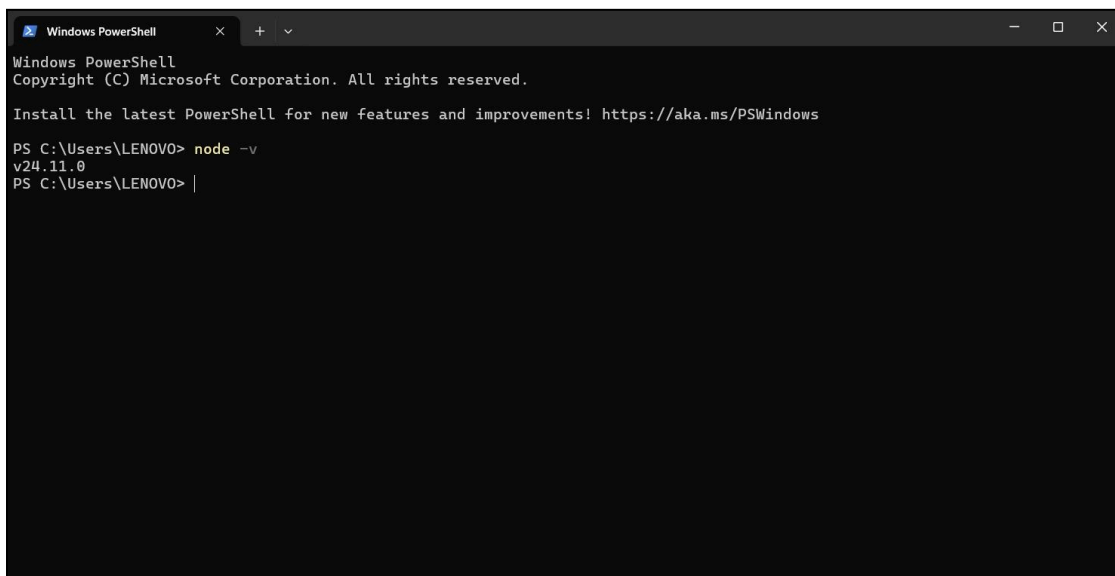
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Tip: After installation, verify Node.js by running `node -v` in your terminal.



```
Windows PowerShell
Copyright (C) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

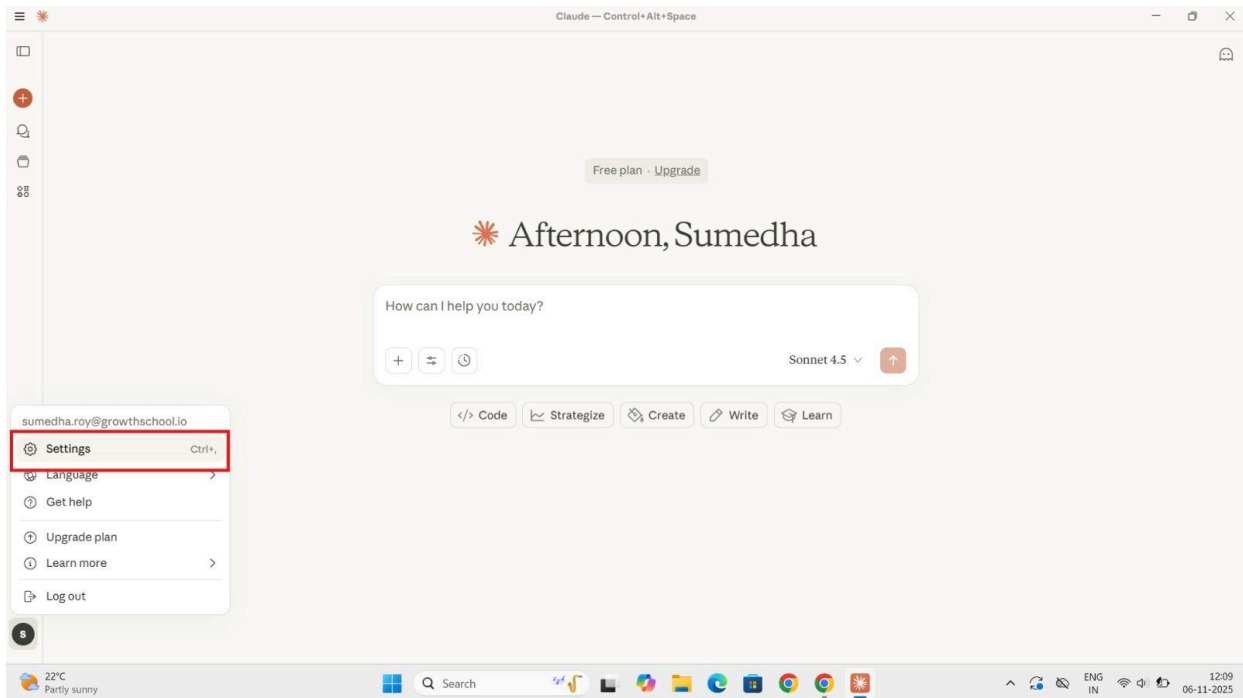
Install the latest PowerShell for new features and improvements! https://aka.ms/PSWindows

PS C:\Users\LENOVO> node -v
v24.11.0
PS C:\Users\LENOVO> |
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Step-by-Step Instructions

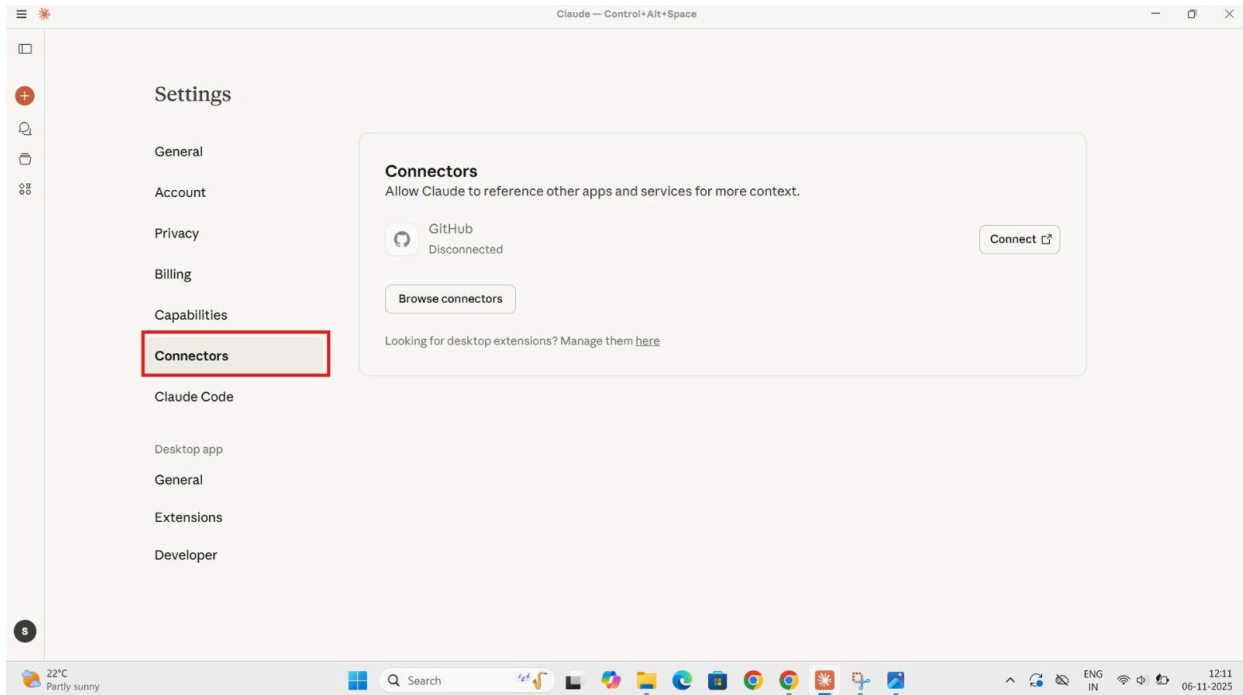
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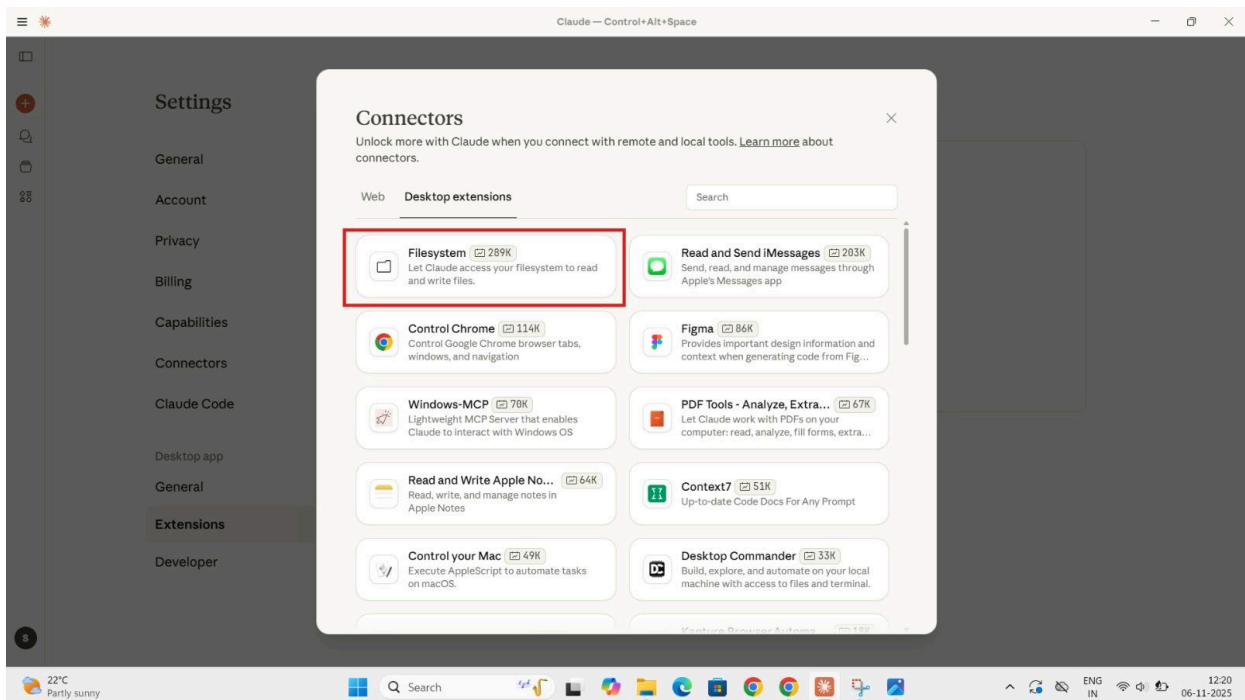
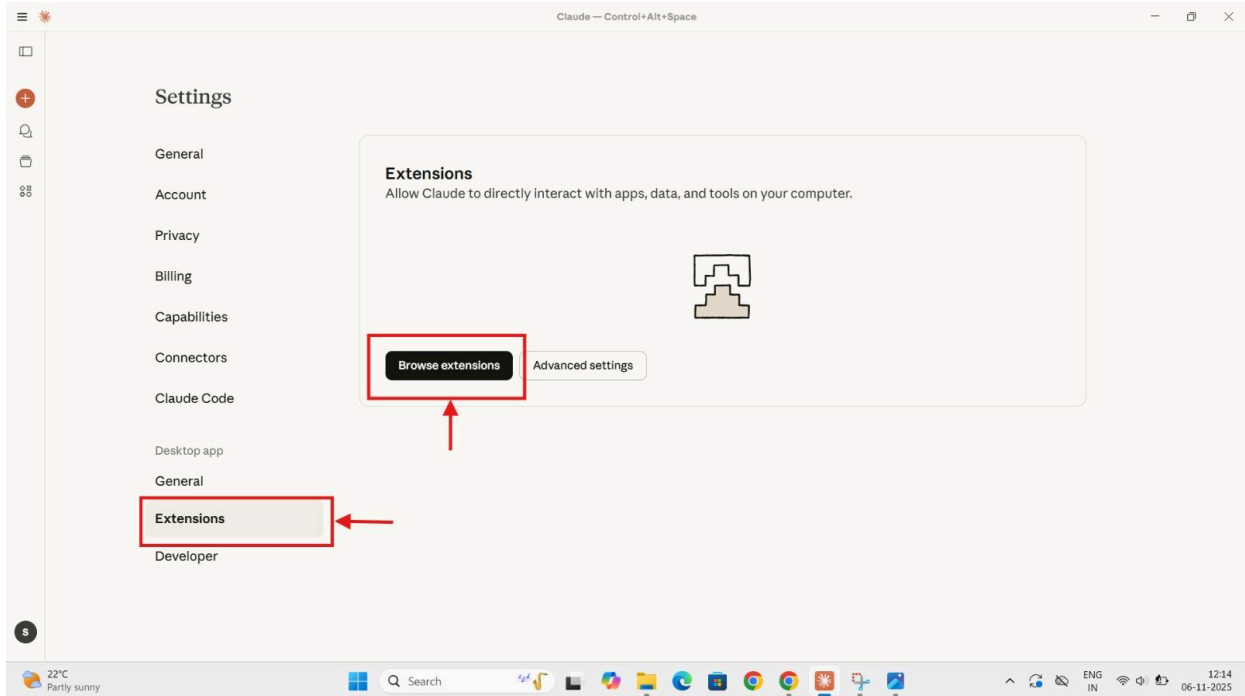


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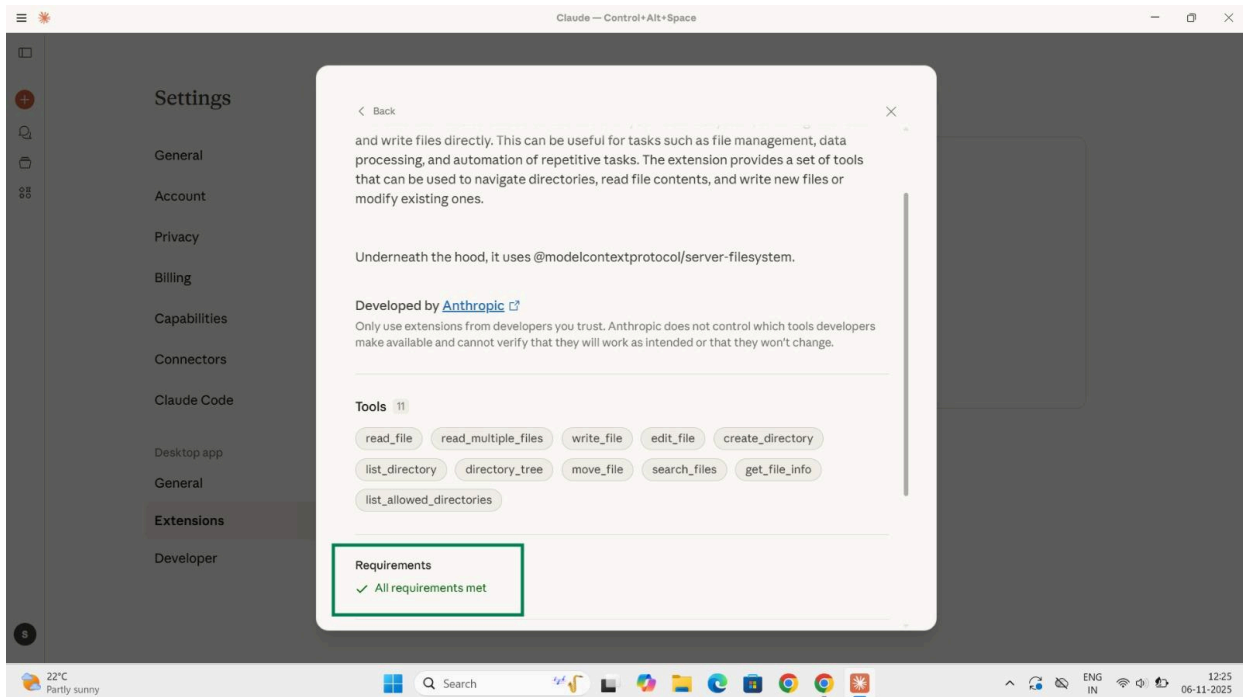
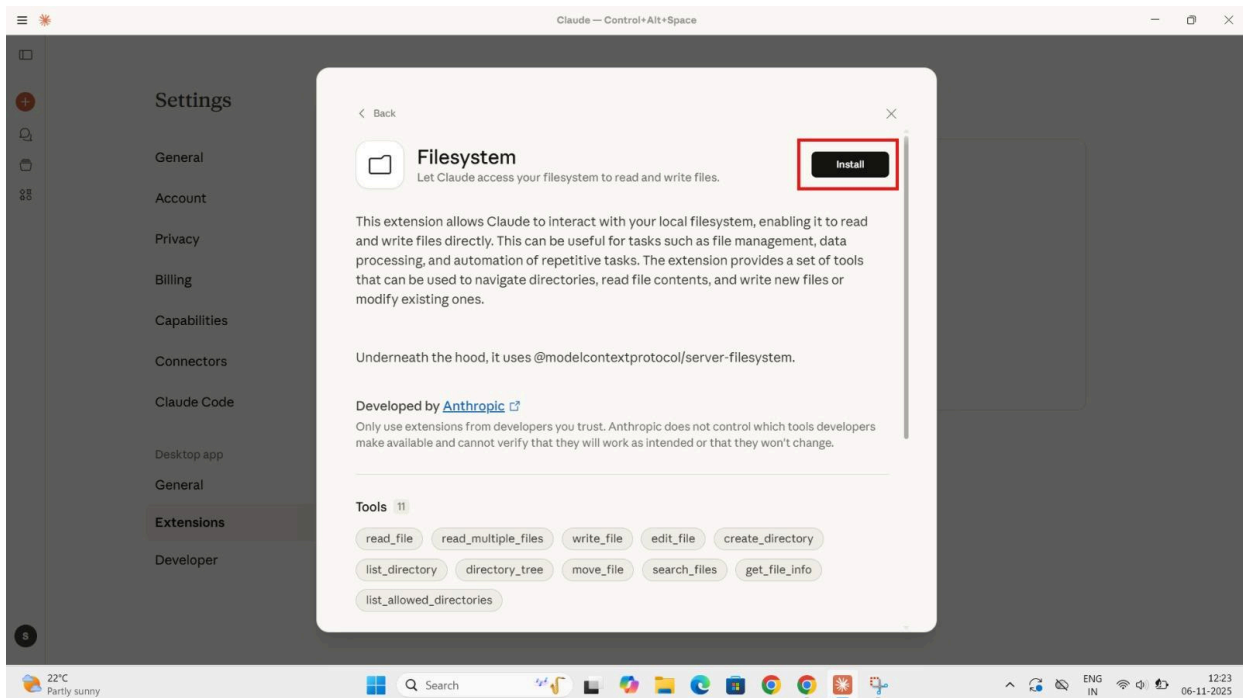
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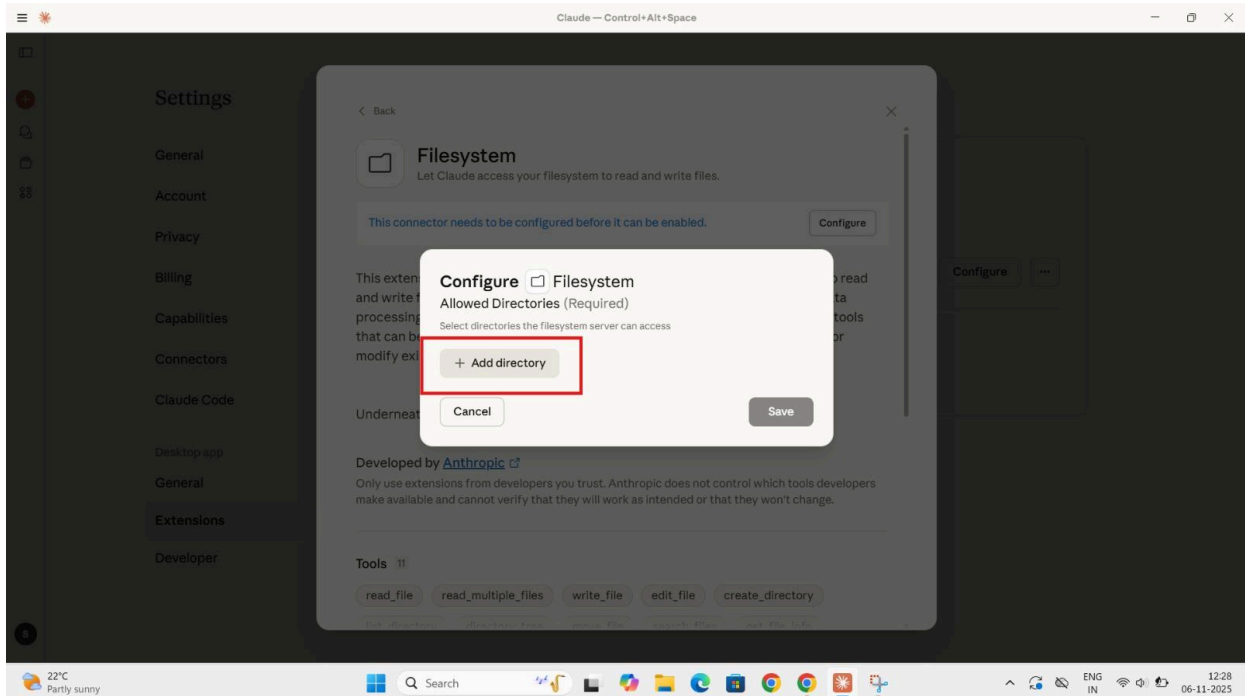
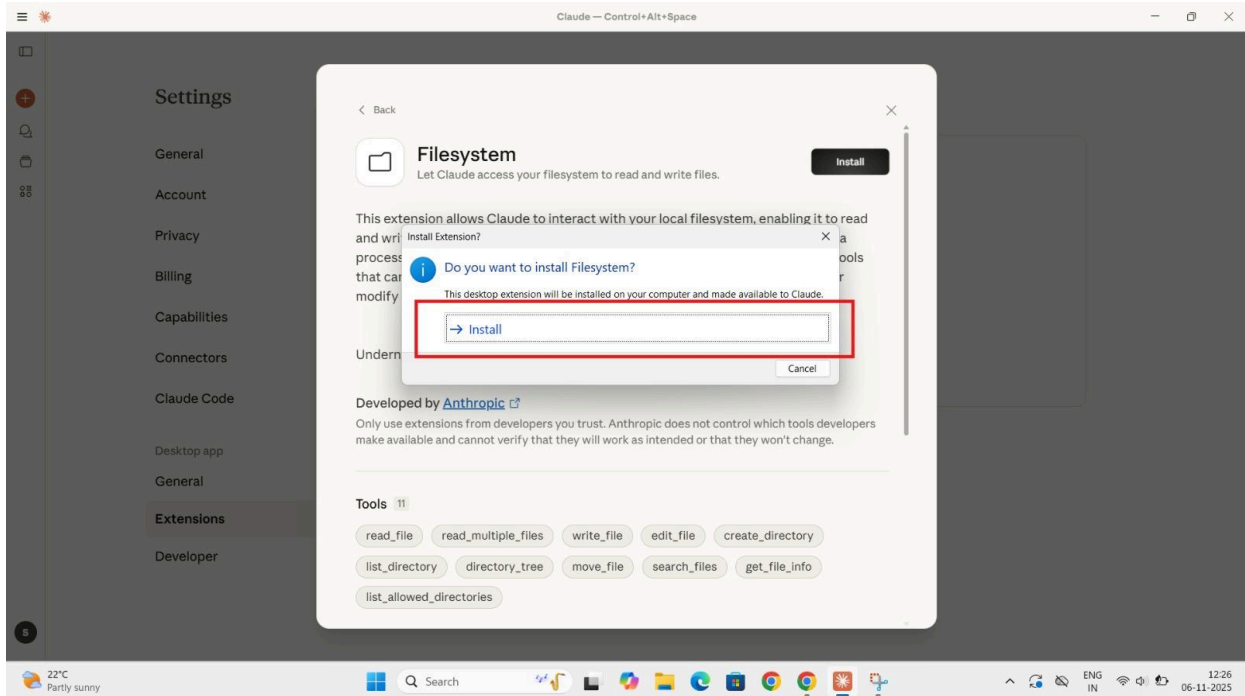


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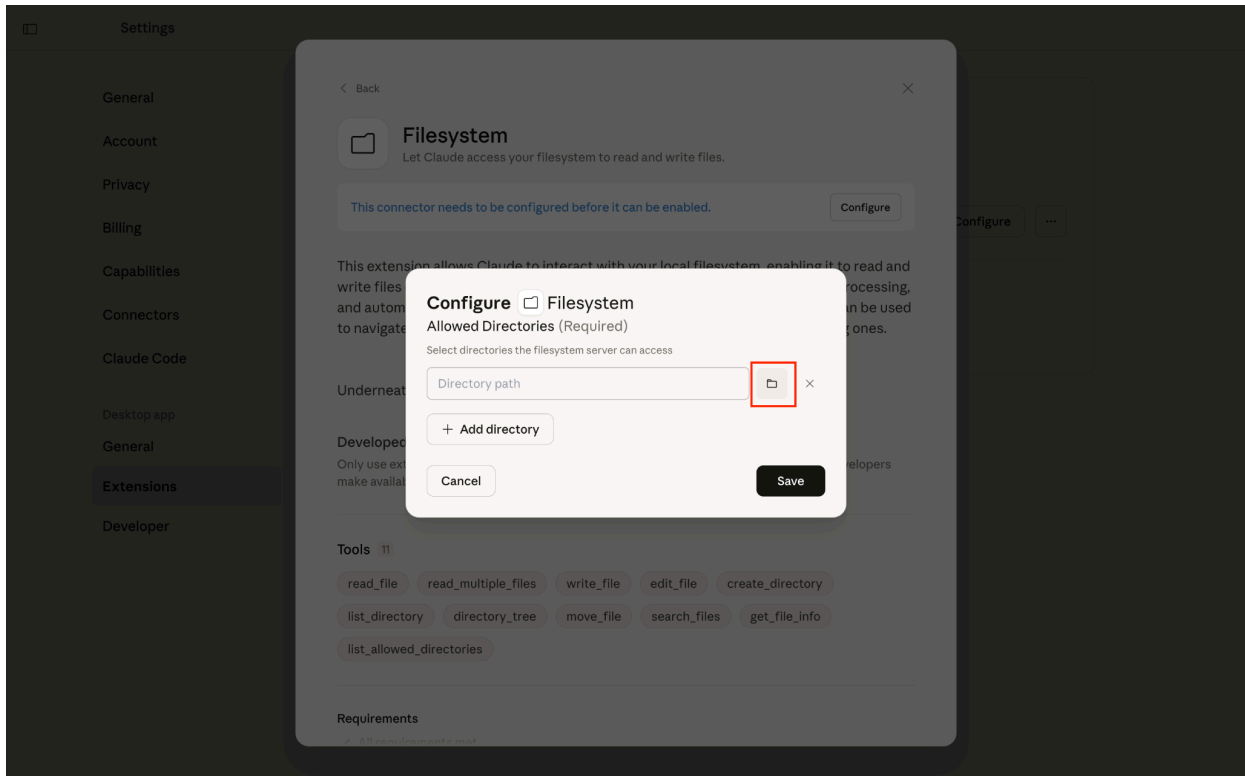


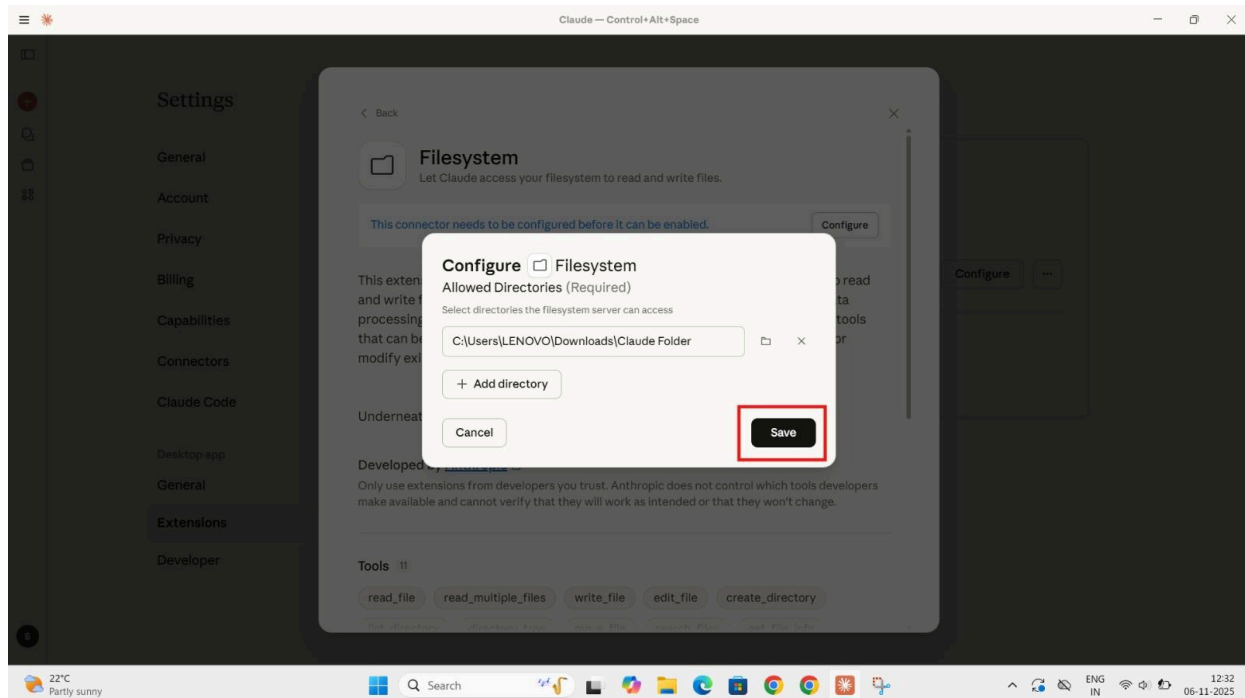


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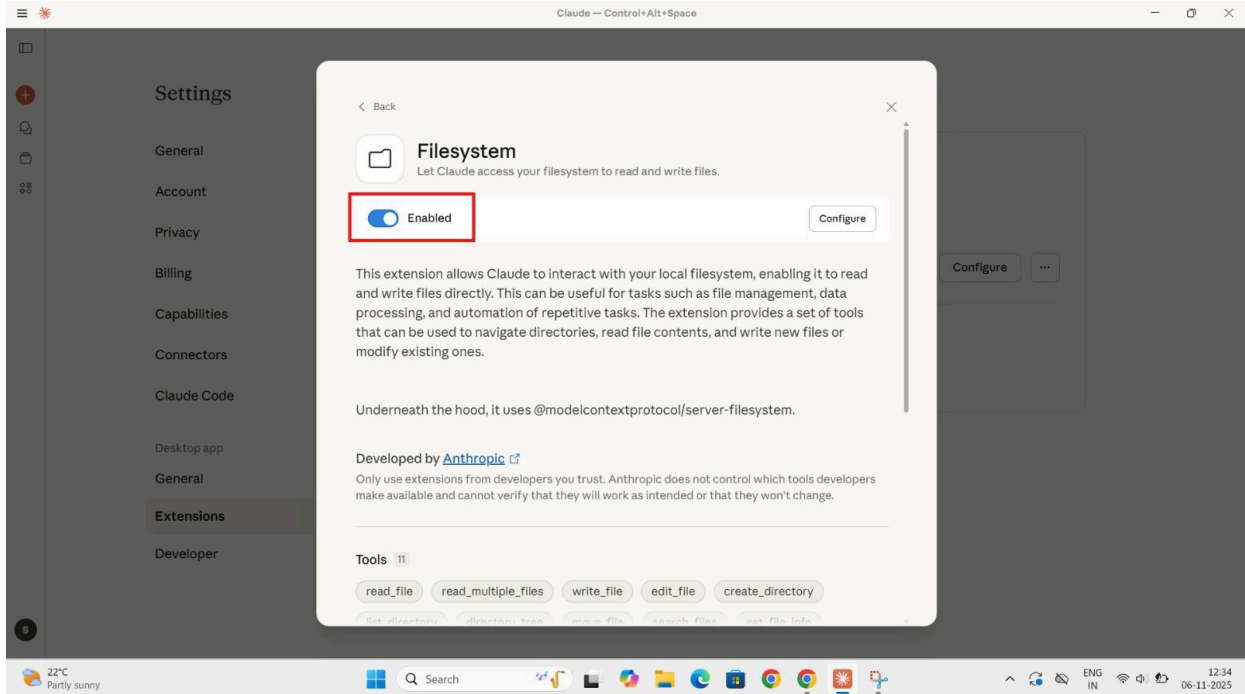




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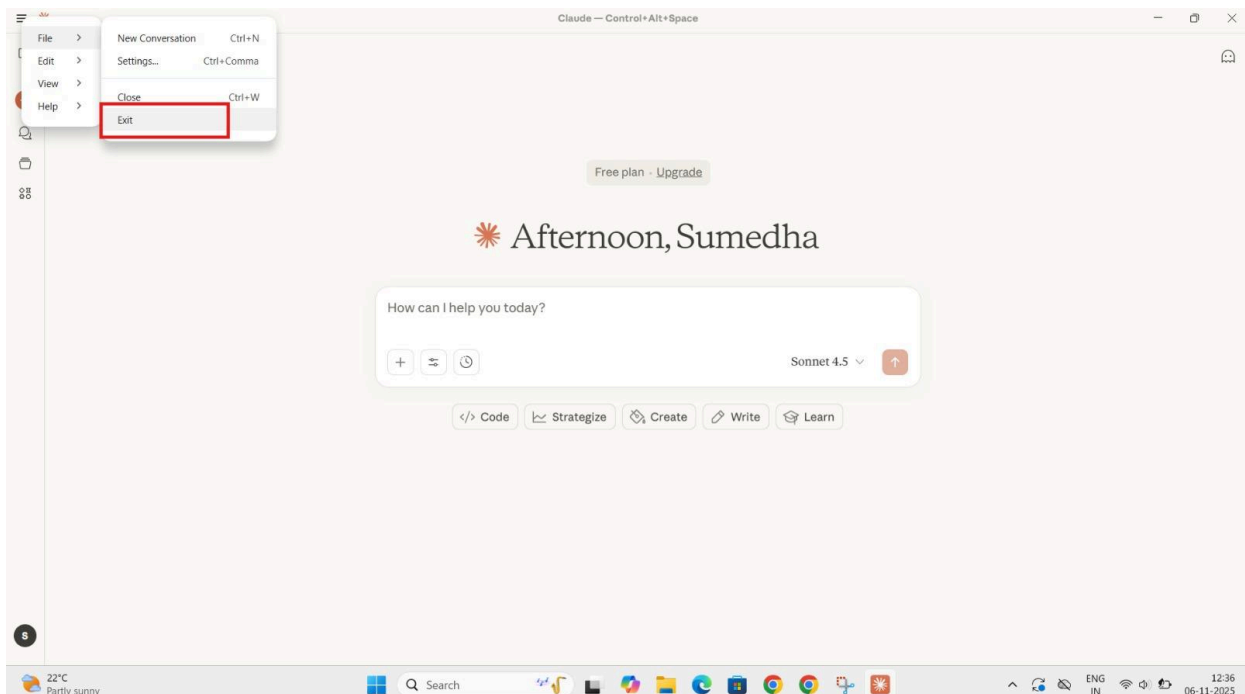
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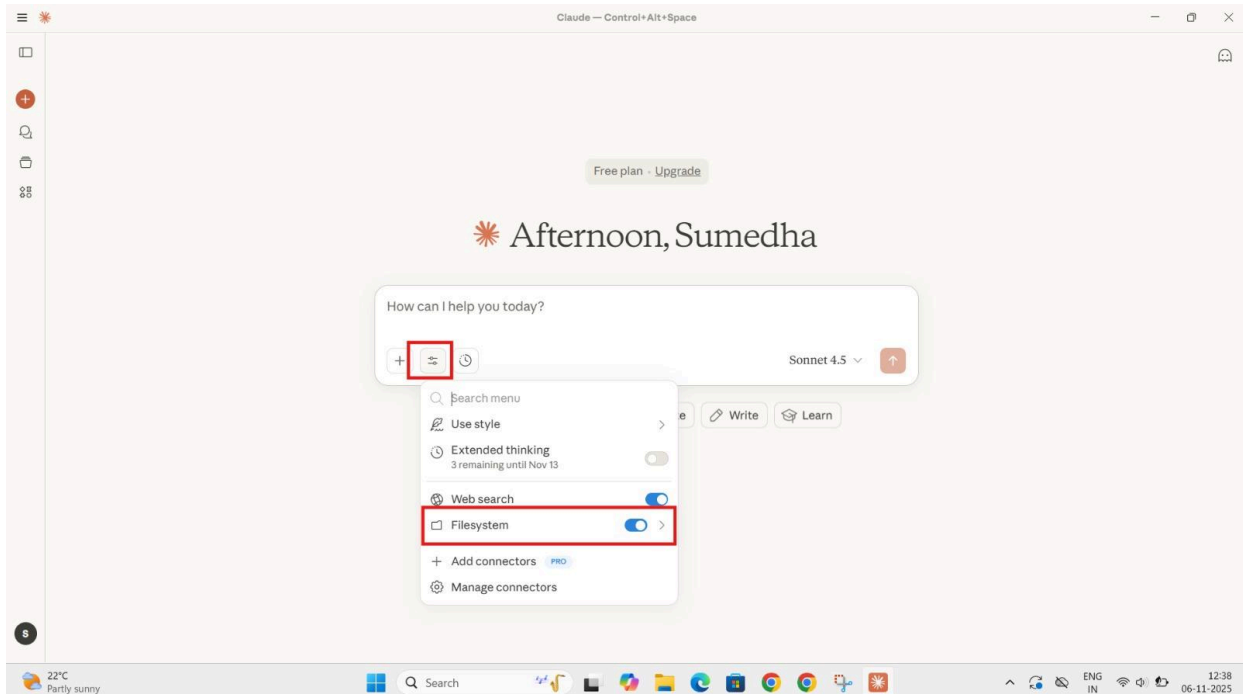
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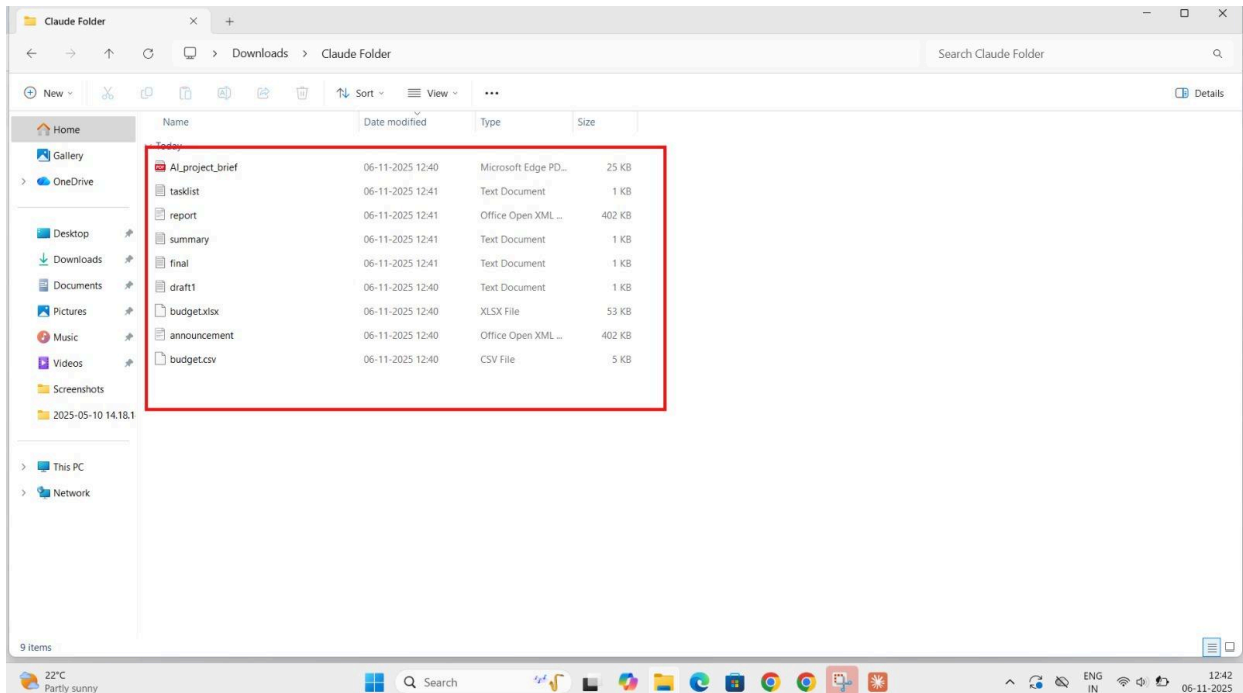
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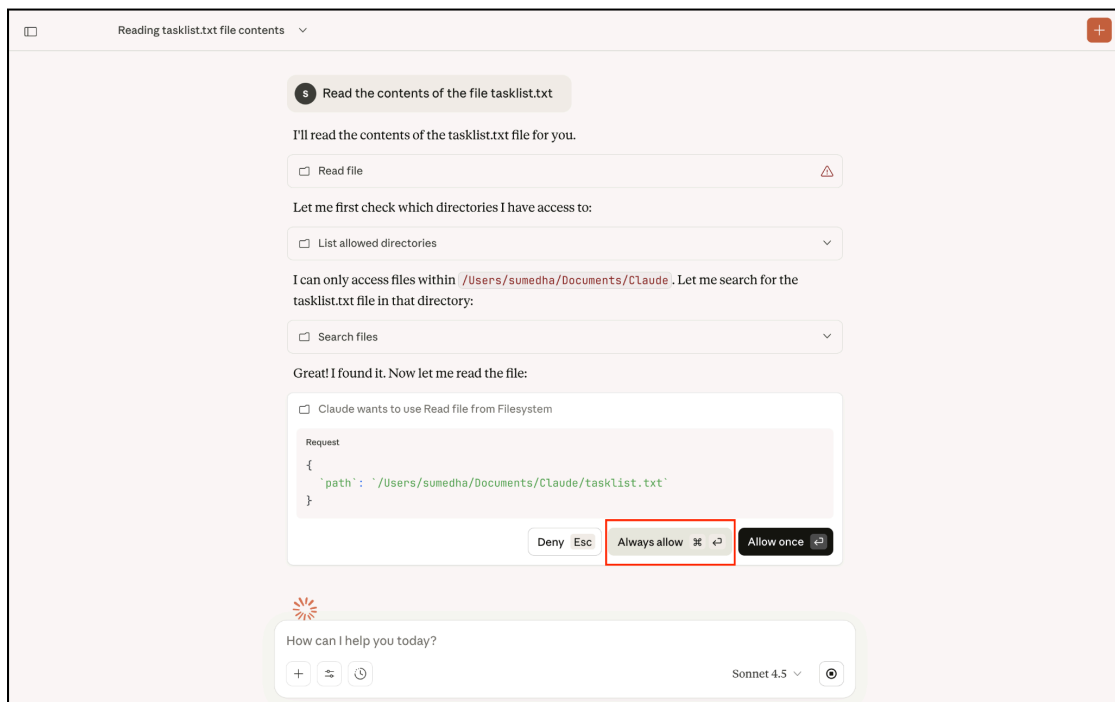
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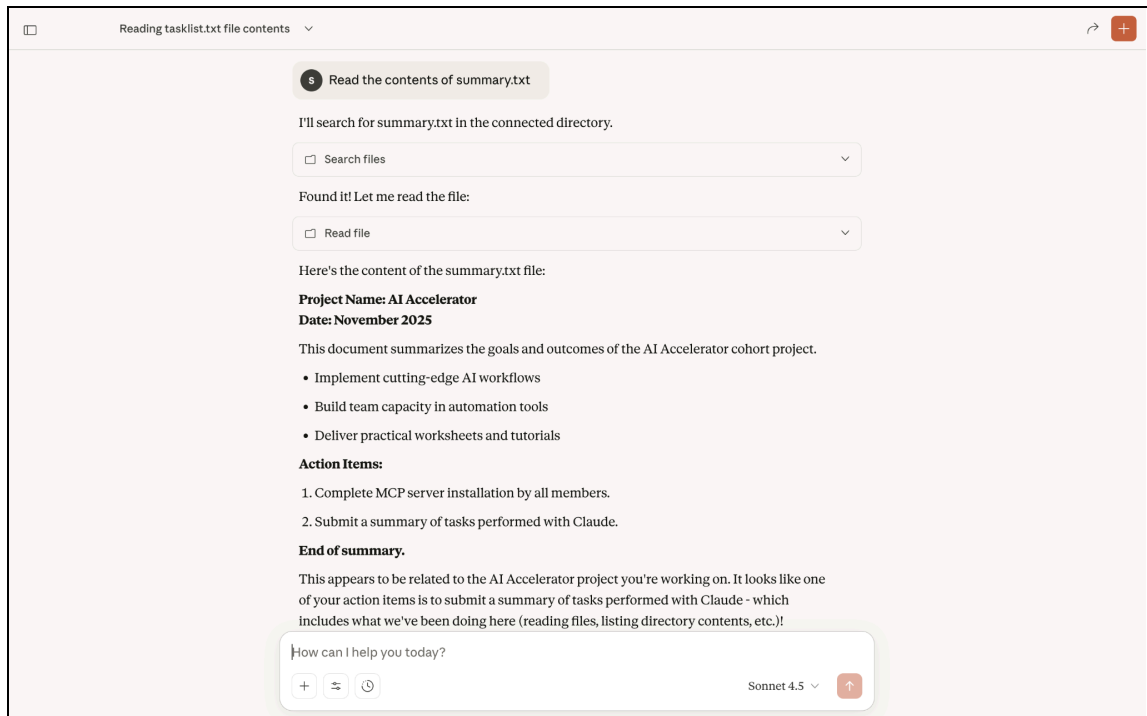
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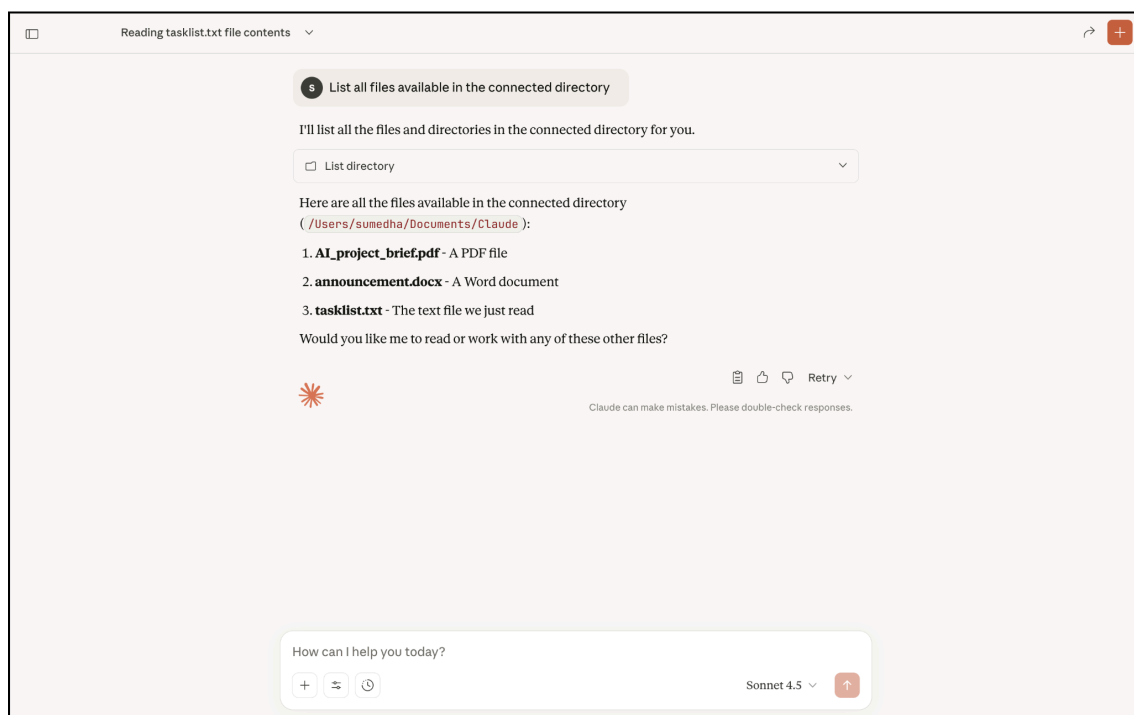
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